

TECHNOLOGY TO Aid the Disabled



Using free software, an easy-to-program framework and inexpensive computer tools, Arun Mehta from Delhi has designed a communication system for a child suffering from cerebral palsy. The best part is, the technology can be extended and applied for the benefit of many more such children.

Arpit is a child suffering from cerebral palsy*. His condition restricts him from physical (motor) activities that are quite normal to human beings. He also finds it hard to speak and move. In today's world, we all are aware of the role that computers have begun to play in our lives. Computing has evolved from being a stationary machine, to enabling people on the move via handheld devices. The dependence on computers has increased so much that being a computer illiterate is considered akin to being illiterate altogether. But the situation is very different for people like Arpit, who are suffering from

disabilities, and for whom computing devices offer little help.

[*As stated in Wikipedia, cerebral palsy (CP) is an umbrella term encompassing a group of non-progressive, non-contagious motor conditions that cause physical disability in human development, chiefly in the various areas of body movement.]

It is this challenge that motivated Arun Mehta, a passionate engineer, to develop a one-of-a-kind solution to help Arpit learn the basics of communication using computers. In no time, the child was able to type his name, identify pictures, and play games, among other things—just like normal people.